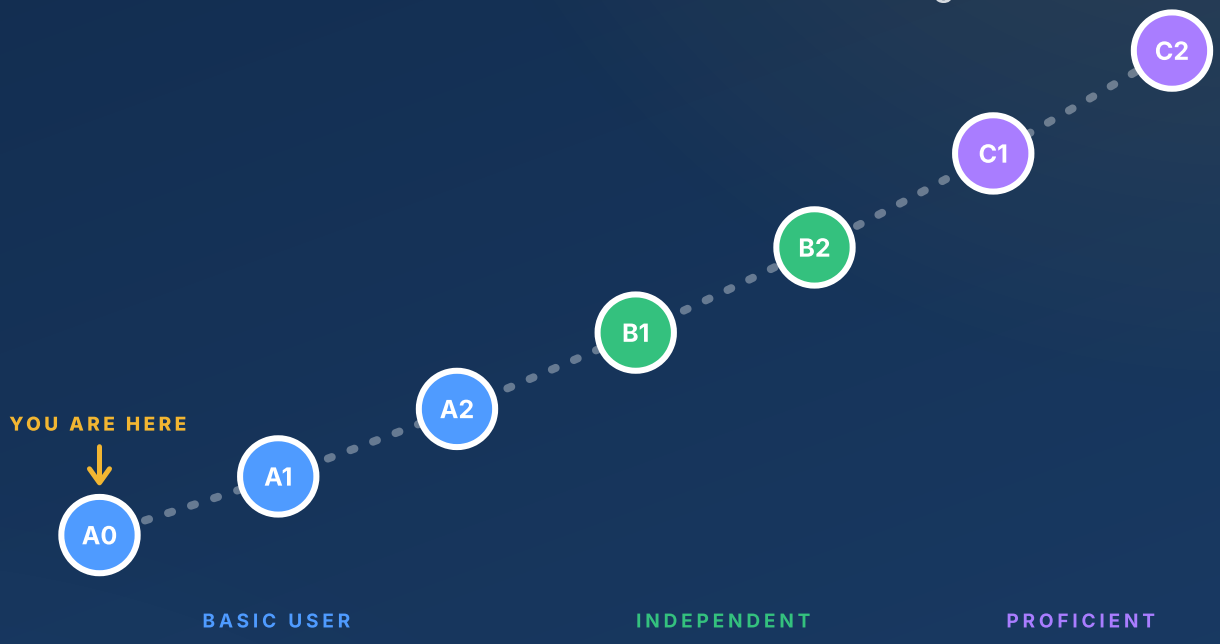
DEUTSCHFOKUS

GERMAN LEARNING ROADMAP · A0 → C2

Your German Journey

From A0 to C2 — A Practical Guide for Efficient Learning



Sprache ist der Schlüssel zu neuen Welten.

Language is the key to new worlds.

"Small steps every day beat giant leaps once a week."

For motivated adult learners with 20–30 minutes per day

Version 2.0 · November 2026

Contents

How to navigate: every line below is clickable. Your PDF reader's *bookmarks* panel is another quick way to jump between sections.

PART 1	**Start Here** Read before your first lesson — about 30 minutes	**3**
1	Welcome — Read This First	3
2	The Levels at a Glance	4
3	The Method — How to Learn German Efficiently	5
4	How to Get the Most Out of Our Lessons	9
5	A0 — Your First Steps	11
6	Your First Week	13
PART 2	**Your Level Roadmap** Read only your current level	**15**
7	A1 — Beginner	15
8	A2 — Elementary	18
9	B1 — Intermediate	21
10	B2 — Upper Intermediate	23
11	C1 — Advanced	25
12	C2 — Mastery & Nuance	27
PART 3	**Skills Toolbox** Come back whenever you need it	**28**
13	Pronunciation & Prosody	28
14	Mediation — The Fifth Skill	31
15	Self-Correction & Editing	32
16	Why This Works — The Science	34
17	Realistic Timelines & Exams	35
18	Bring German Into Your Life	37
19	Common Pitfalls & Fossilized Errors	38
20	Motivation & Mindset	39
PART 4	**Tools & Templates** Print what you need	**40**
21	Resource Directory	40
22	Printable Templates	43
	See You in Lesson One	52

PART 1

Start Here

Everything you need before your first lesson: how this guide works, what the levels mean, the method, how our lessons work, your very first steps — and a plan for your first seven days.

1 Welcome — Read This First

Willkommen! You are about to start learning German — and this guide shows you how to do it efficiently, even with a busy life.

It answers one question: **what should you actually do, every day, to learn German from zero?**

The short answer:

1. **Do a little German every day.** 20–30 minutes is enough. Even 10 minutes count.
2. **Speak from Day 1** — out loud, imperfectly, every day.
3. **Use a few good resources consistently** instead of many resources occasionally.
4. **Reuse your corrections.** A mistake you fix and reuse is worth more than ten new words.

The long answer is the rest of this guide.

How to Read This Guide

Part	What's inside	When to read it
1 · Start Here	The method, our lessons, your first steps and first week	**Now** — about 30 minutes
2 · Level Roadmap	One chapter per level, A1 to C2	**Only your current level**
3 · Skills Toolbox	Pronunciation, self-correction, timelines, exams, mindset …	Whenever you need it
4 · Tools & Templates	All resources with QR codes, printable trackers	Print what you need

> **You don't need to read everything.** You don't need to understand everything. You don't need the perfect app. You need to start — and to come back tomorrow.

Three Promises to Yourself

- [ ] I will do something in German every day — even if it is only 10 minutes.
- [ ] I will speak German out loud from Day 1, even when it sounds wrong.
- [ ] I will treat mistakes as information, not as failure.

Bis bald — see you soon! *Oguzhan*

2 The Levels at a Glance

German courses, exams and this guide all use the **CEFR** — the *Common European Framework of Reference for Languages*. It describes six levels, from A1 to C2. This guide adds **A0**: your very first steps.

Level	Name	In real life, you can …
A0	**Starter**	say hello, your name, *bitte* and *danke* — and you know how German sounds
A1	**Beginner**	introduce yourself, order food, ask simple questions, understand slow and clear speech about familiar things
A2	**Elementary**	talk about your day, the past and your plans; handle routine situations like shopping, appointments and directions
B1	**Intermediate**	handle most everyday situations, tell a story, give your opinion with reasons, follow the main points of clear standard German
B2	**Upper intermediate**	follow normal native speech on most topics, discuss and defend an opinion, use German at work in many jobs
C1	**Advanced**	understand demanding texts and implicit meaning, speak fluently and spontaneously, use German flexibly for work and study
C2	**Mastery**	understand virtually everything and express fine shades of meaning precisely

Three Zones

This guide groups the levels into three color zones. Each zone has a different main goal — and a different main speaking habit.

Zone	Levels	Main goal	Main speaking habit
🔵 **Blue zone** — basic user	A0 · A1 · A2	Survive and connect	One Natulang lesson every day
🟢 **Green zone** — independent user	B1 · B2	Express real ideas	Retelling, conversation, discussion
🟣 **Purple zone** — proficient user	C1 · C2	Precision, nuance and style	Debates, presentations, editing for style

Where Are You Now?

If you have never studied German before, you are at **A0** — the perfect place to start. Read the rest of Part 1, then follow Your First Week.

Already know some German? Look at the can-do checklists in Part 2 and find the first level where you can't tick most of the boxes. That is the level to work on now. **We will check it together in our first lesson.**

> **How long does it take?** Roughly 60–150 hours of learning to reach A1, and 260–490 hours to reach B1 (Goethe-Institut estimates). Realistic Timelines & Exams turns these hours into months for your schedule.

3 The Method — How to Learn German Efficiently

German does not require a perfect study system. It requires a good system that you actually use.

If you only have 20–30 minutes per day, your goal is not to squeeze ten different resources into your routine. Your goal is to make a few high-value activities automatic.

The Four Pillars

Build your German around four pillars:

Pillar	What it means	Core question
🎧 **Input**	Listen to (and later read) German you can mostly understand	Can I understand more than last month?
📖 **Course**	Follow one structured path — our lessons plus one course	Do I know what to learn next?
🧠 **Vocabulary**	Remember useful words and phrases	Can I recall them when I need them?
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Speak and write	Can I actually use what I know?

You do not need ten apps, six grammar books and four YouTube channels. A small number of activities produces most of your progress — these four, used consistently.

The 20-Minute Rule

Twenty focused minutes every day usually beat one exhausted two-hour session at the weekend. Your memory is built by repetition and sleep — daily contact gives it both.

A simple 20–30-minute session

- **5 min** — 🧠 review vocabulary (Anki or flashcards)
- **10–15 min** — 🗣️ speaking (from A0 to A2: your Natulang lesson)
- **5–10 min** — 🎧 listening, 📖 course work or ✍️ writing — rotate during the week

On busy days, do your minimum: one Natulang lesson, *or* five minutes of flashcards plus three sentences said out loud. Even 10 minutes count. The goal is to protect your streak of meaningful contact with German — and if you miss a day, never miss two in a row.

The Speaking Rule

Speak from Day 1.

Do not wait until your grammar is "good enough." Say:

> **Ich heiße Maria.**
> **Ich komme aus Spanien.**
> **Ich wohne in Berlin.**

Simple sentences are real German. Imperfect German spoken today is worth more than perfect German that stays inside your head.

The Natulang Rule

🗣️ **From A0 to the end of A2: one Natulang lesson every day.**

Natulang is your daily speaking companion. A lesson takes **about 10–15 minutes**, and you answer everything out loud — the app listens and checks you.

This is your minimum daily speaking habit: a low-friction way to start speaking before you feel "ready."

natulang.com

From B1 onward, Natulang becomes optional. You can keep using it for review, pronunciation, automatic sentence building or extra speaking on busy days. But your main speaking practice should move toward retelling, spontaneous answers, conversations, explanations and discussions.

The Article Rule

Every German noun has a gender: **der** (masculine), **die** (feminine) or **das** (neuter). The article changes other words in the sentence, so you need it from the very beginning — and it is far easier to learn it together with the word than to add it later.

> ❌ *Tisch* — table
> ✅ **der Tisch, die Tische** — the table, the tables

- Learn every noun **with its article and its plural**.
- Say it out loud with the article: *der Tisch, der Tisch, der Tisch.*
- Color-code if it helps: many learners write **der** words in blue, **die** words in red and **das** words in green.

Some patterns make it easier:

If the noun ...	it is ...	Examples
ends in **-ung, -heit, -keit, -schaft, -ion, -tät**	**die**	die Zeitung, die Freiheit, die Information
ends in **-chen** or **-lein**	**das**	das Mädchen, das Brötchen
is a day, a month or a season	**der**	der Montag, der Mai, der Winter
is plural	**die**	die Kinder, die Bücher

The Review Rule

Corrections are valuable only when you reuse them. Do not simply read

> ❌ *Ich warte dich.*

and move on. Write down the correct version:

> ✅ **Ich warte auf dich.**

Then make a new sentence with the same pattern:

> **Ich warte auf den Bus.**

Then use it again two days later.

Notice → Understand → Rewrite → Reuse → Review

The 3-Pass Method

Use this for short videos, podcasts with transcripts, interviews and short texts.

1. **Pass 1 — Support.** Listen or watch with subtitles in your strongest language if necessary. Understand the message.
2. **Pass 2 — German.** Use German subtitles or the German transcript. Notice vocabulary, structures, pronunciation and connectors.
3. **Pass 3 — No support.** Listen again without subtitles. Your brain now has enough context to hear much more.

> **Important:** don't use three passes for everything. Use the method selectively, for short and useful material.

Retelling — Your Main Tool From B1

Retelling turns passive understanding into active German. You will use it a lot from B1 on — and in a simple form already at A2.

The 5-Keyword Method

1. 🎧 Watch or 📖 read something short.
2. Write down only **five keywords**.
3. Close the source.
4. Explain what happened in your own words — out loud.
5. Compare your version with the original.

Example keywords: *Zug — Verspätung — Termin — Taxi — geschafft*

> *Gestern hatte mein Zug Verspätung. Ich hatte aber einen wichtigen Termin. Deshalb habe ich schließlich ein Taxi genommen. Zum Glück habe ich es noch rechtzeitig geschafft.*

This single exercise trains memory, vocabulary retrieval, grammar, sentence linking and speaking fluency.

Your One-Week Starter Planner

Tick a box every day you work on a pillar.

Pillar	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
📖 Course	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🎧 Input	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🧠 Vocabulary	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🗣️✍️ Output	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

My minimum daily study time: _____ minutes
My best study time: _____
My German-free day, if I need one: _____

Your SMARTA Goal

A good goal is SMARTA:

S
Specific
What exactly will I achieve?

M
Measurable
How will I know I did it?

A
Achievable
Is this realistic?

R
Relevant
Does it move me toward my real goal?

T
Time-bound
By when?

A
Action-oriented
What will I actually do each week?

SMARTA examples by level

Level	Example
A0	Within 7 days, I will introduce myself using five memorized German sentences and complete one Natulang lesson daily.
A1	Within 6 weeks, I will speak for two minutes about myself without reading a script.
A2	Within 8 weeks, I will tell a simple story about last weekend using the Perfekt and at least five connectors.
B1	Within 10 weeks, I will retell a three-minute German video in my own words for two minutes.
B2	Within 12 weeks, I will discuss a controversial topic for five minutes and support my opinion with three arguments.
C1	Within 12 weeks, I will give a spontaneous ten-minute explanation of a topic from my professional field.
C2	Over the next 12 weeks, I will improve my stylistic precision by rewriting one advanced text every week after feedback.

Write your own goal on the SMARTA Goal Sheet in Part 4.

4 How to Get the Most Out of Our Lessons

Our lessons are where you get explanations, feedback and real conversation. But most of your progress happens **between** lessons — in your daily 20–30 minutes. This chapter connects the two.

Before Each Lesson — 10 Minutes

- [ ] Review your notes and corrections from the last lesson.
- [ ] Prepare **one or two questions** — about grammar, a word, or something you heard or read.
- [ ] Prepare **one thing to tell me in German**: what you did, something that happened, something you saw. Three sentences are perfect.
- [ ] Have your lesson notebook (or document) ready for corrections.
- [ ] If we meet online: test your microphone and headphones before the lesson starts.

During the Lesson

- **Speak as much as you can.** The lesson is your speaking time.
- **Manage the lesson in German** with the survival kit below — from the very first day.
- **Mistakes are welcome.** I will correct some, not all, so that the conversation can keep flowing.
- **Write down corrections and new phrases as complete sentences**, not as single words.

After the Lesson — Within 24 Hours

- [ ] Review your corrections while they are still fresh.
- [ ] Put the **5–10 most useful** new phrases into Anki or your vocabulary notebook.
- [ ] Rewrite at least one corrected sentence — then make a new sentence with the same pattern.
- [ ] Do your homework, if there is any.
- [ ] Use one new phrase within two days: in real life, in a message, or out loud to yourself.

Your Lesson Survival Kit

You can use all of these in your very first lesson. *Sie* is the formal "you," *du* the informal one — we will agree on one in our first lesson.

German	English
Wie bitte?	Sorry? / Pardon?
Können Sie das bitte wiederholen? · Kannst du das bitte wiederholen?	Can you repeat that, please?
Langsamer, bitte.	Slower, please.
Noch einmal, bitte.	Once more, please.
Was bedeutet …?	What does … mean?
Wie sagt man … auf Deutsch?	How do you say … in German?
Wie heißt das auf Deutsch?	What is this called in German?
Wie schreibt man das?	How do you spell that?
Ich verstehe das nicht.	I don't understand that.
Ich habe eine Frage.	I have a question.
Ist das richtig?	Is that correct?
Moment, ich muss kurz überlegen.	One moment, I need to think.

Your Lesson Notebook

Keep one place for everything from our lessons — a paper notebook, a document, or the Lesson Notes template in Part 4. For every lesson, write down:

- the **date** and the main topic,
- **new phrases** — as complete sentences,
- **corrections**: ❌ what you said → ✅ the correct version,
- **questions** for next time,
- your **homework**.

> **The students who improve fastest are rarely the most talented ones.** They are the ones who come back to their notes between lessons.

5 A0 — Your First Steps

A0 · BLUE ZONE

Your Goal

A0 means: you are starting from zero — and that is completely fine. Your first goal is not grammar mastery. It is:

confidence + sound recognition + first useful sentences

Your First 10 German Expressions

German	English
Hallo!	Hello!
Guten Tag!	Good day! / Hello! (a little more formal)
Tschüss!	Bye!
Ich heiße …	My name is …
Wie heißt du? · Wie heißen Sie?	What's your name? (informal · formal)
Bitte.	Please. / You're welcome.
Danke.	Thank you.
Ja.	Yes.
Nein.	No.
Entschuldigung.	Excuse me. / Sorry.

Say them out loud. Do not only read them.

> **du or Sie?** German has two words for "you." Use **Sie** with strangers, officials, in shops and in formal situations. Use **du** with friends, family, children — and with anyone who offers it (*"Wir können uns duzen."*). When in doubt, start with **Sie**.

Meet the German Alphabet

Pay special attention to the four letters English doesn't have:

ä
Mädchen
like the *e* in *bed*

ö
schön
say "ay" as in *say* — then round your lips

ü
Tür
say "ee" as in *see* — then round your lips

ß
Straße
a sharp *s*, like *ss*

Don’t worry about mastering them immediately. Your first job is simply to notice that these sounds matter. All the rules are waiting in Pronunciation & Prosody when you are ready.

Your 5-Minute Starter Routine

1. **Minute 1:** Say aloud: *Hallo. Ich heiße …*
2. **Minutes 2–3:** Listen to one very short piece of slow German.
3. **Minutes 4–5:** Repeat three familiar-looking German words — with their articles.
4. **Then:** complete today’s Natulang lesson.

🗣️ **Natulang — one lesson per day, about 10–15 minutes.**

Start today. Your job is not to sound perfect. Your job is to build the habit: **German goes into my ears → German comes out of my mouth.**

natulang.com

What NOT to Do Yet

- ✕ Don’t memorize enormous grammar tables.
- ✕ Don’t study every possible article rule.
- ✕ Don’t translate every single word.
- ✕ Don’t collect hundreds of vocabulary cards.
- ✕ Don’t wait until you “know enough” to speak.

Your first German should be small and usable.

German Words You Already Almost Know

German	English	German	English
die Hand	hand	der Computer	computer
der Finger	finger	die Banane	banana
der Arm	arm	das Telefon	telephone
der Kindergarten	kindergarten	das Problem	problem
das Restaurant	restaurant	der Film	film

You are not beginning with nothing — your brain already recognizes more German than you think. And notice that every word comes **with its article**: that is the Article Rule in action.

6 Your First Week

Seven days from zero

You do not need to prepare. Start. Each day takes about 20–30 minutes, including your Natulang lesson.

Day 1 — Say Your Name

Learn: *Hallo. Ich heiße …* Look at the German alphabet and pay attention to **ä — ö — ü — ß**.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete your first Natulang lesson.

Day 2 — Listen

Watch or listen to one short beginner-friendly German clip — for example a "Super Easy German" episode from Easy German. Choose three phrases and repeat each one aloud several times.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Day 3 — Discover Familiar Words

Learn ten cognates with their articles: *die Hand, der Finger, der Arm, der Kindergarten, das Restaurant, der Computer, die Banane, das Telefon, das Problem, der Film.* Say every word aloud.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Day 4 — Numbers

Learn *eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn.* Then say random numbers between one and ten without looking at the list.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Day 5 — Your First Recording

Record yourself:

> **Hallo! Ich heiße … Ich komme aus … Ich wohne in … Ich spreche …**

Don't worry if your recording is shorter than one minute. Save it — you will want to hear it again in a few months.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Day 6 — Review

Without looking, try to remember the ten expressions, the numbers 1–10, your self-introduction and five cognates. Then check.

☐ I spoke German this week. ☐ I listened to German. ☐ I learned my first phrases. ☐ I made mistakes. ☐ **I continued anyway.**

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Day 7 — Enjoy German

Today can be lighter. Watch part of a German film or series, a beginner video, children's content — any German content you genuinely enjoy. Use subtitles. You are not taking an exam. You are getting used to the language.

🗣️ Natulang: ☐ Complete today's lesson.

Your first seven Natulang lessons	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Lesson completed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

First-Week Checklist

- ☐ I can say *Hallo* and *Tschüss* naturally.
- ☐ I can say my name.
- ☐ I know when to use *du* and when to use *Sie*.
- ☐ I recognize ä, ö, ü and ß.
- ☐ I can say *Bitte* and *Danke*.
- ☐ I know at least ten cognates — with their articles.
- ☐ I have spoken German out loud every day.
- ☐ I completed one Natulang lesson per day.

Then bring your questions — and your Day 5 recording — to our next lesson.

Your mission is not perfection. Your mission is momentum.

PART 2

Your Level Roadmap

One chapter per level, from A1 to C2. **Read only the chapter for your current level.** Every chapter follows the same structure: your goal, your four pillars, what to focus on, a can-do checklist and the most common trap. When you can tick most of the can-do checklist, move on to the next chapter.

7 A1 — Beginner

A1 · BLUE ZONE

Your Goal

At A1, you learn to handle simple everyday communication. Step by step, you become able to talk about yourself, your family, your day, your home and your routines.

Your Four Pillars

Pillar	Recommended	Backup	Minimum effective dose	Success check
📖 **Course**	Our lessons + Nicos Weg (DW) A1	A structured A1 textbook	15–20 min, 3× per week	I understand the grammar and vocabulary of my current unit.
🎧 **Input**	Easy German — "Super Easy German"	DW Learn German beginner videos	5–10 min, 4× per week	I understand the main idea of slow speech about familiar topics.
🧠 **Vocabulary**	Anki	Paper flashcards	5–10 min daily	I actively recall useful phrases — not only recognize them.
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Natulang — one lesson daily	A 1-minute voice recording	10–15 min daily	I can introduce myself without reading every sentence.

🗣️ **Your A1 speaking habit:** complete **one Natulang lesson every day.** This is your minimum speaking dose.

If you have more time, add a short self-recording, questions in our lessons, a language partner, or talking to yourself while walking. But never replace daily speaking with passive study.

What to Learn at A1

- present tense of regular and common irregular verbs
- **sein** and **haben**
- word order: the verb in position 2
- W-questions and yes/no questions
- negation with **nicht** and **kein**
- nominative and basic accusative
- modal verbs: *können, müssen, wollen, möchten*
- separable verbs: *aufstehen, einkaufen, anrufen*
- possessives: *mein, dein, Ihr …*
- simple requests: *Komm! Kommen Sie!*
- numbers, dates and clock times
- common prepositions: *in, an, mit, zu, nach*
- your first past forms: *ich war, ich hatte, ich habe … gemacht*

Do not try to understand every exception. Master the structures you need every day. For quick grammar summaries with exercises, see the free German Learning Toolkit.

High-Value Sentence Patterns

> **Ich komme aus …** — I come from …
> **Ich wohne in …** — I live in …
> **Ich arbeite als …** — I work as …
> **Normalerweise …** — Usually …
> **Am Wochenende …** — At the weekend …
> **Ich möchte …** — I would like …
> **Ich muss …** — I have to …
> **Ich kann …** — I can …
> **Ich mag …** — I like …

Watch the verb: ***Am Wochenende spiele ich Fußball.*** The verb stays in position 2 — so *ich* moves behind it.

A1 Can-Do Checklist

- [ ] I can introduce myself in at least three sentences.
- [ ] I can say where I live and where I come from.
- [ ] I can talk briefly about my family.
- [ ] I can order something simple and ask the price.
- [ ] I can understand simple numbers, dates and times.
- [ ] I can describe a normal day.
- [ ] I can ask basic questions — and I know when to use *du* or *Sie*.
- [ ] I can understand very slow German about familiar topics.
- [ ] I can write a short, simple message.
- [ ] I can keep speaking despite making mistakes.

Weekly Speaking Test

Once a week, record yourself for one minute. Topic: ***Stell dich vor*** — introduce yourself. Include your name, country, city, job, languages and a hobby.

Don’t restart every time you make a mistake: fluency grows when you learn to continue. Keep your recordings — comparing this month’s with last month’s is the best motivation there is.

Common A1 pitfall: ❌ "I need more grammar before I can speak."

This often turns into months of preparation without real speaking.

Fix: do your Natulang lesson every day. Record one 1-minute self-introduction per week. Compare this month's recording with last month's.

🧠 **Your first 500 useful words unlock a new world.**

But 500 words you can **use** are worth more than 2,000 words you only recognize.

8 A2 — Elementary

A2 · BLUE ZONE

Your Goal

At A2, German becomes much more practical. You learn to talk about what happened, explain simple plans, handle routine situations, describe experiences and give basic reasons.

Your Four Pillars

Pillar	Recommended	Backup	Minimum effective dose	Success check
📖 **Course**	Our lessons + Nicos Weg A2	A2 textbook + workbook	20 min, 3× per week	I can use the current grammar in my own examples.
🎧 **Input**	"Super Easy German" + short stories for learners	nachrichtenleicht — news in plain German	10 min, 4× per week	I understand the main point without translating every sentence.
🧠 **Vocabulary**	Phrase-based Anki cards	A vocabulary notebook	5–10 min daily	I recall complete chunks such as *sich an etwas erinnern*.
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Natulang daily + one short text per week	Our lessons / a language partner	10–15 min speaking daily + 1 text per week	I can describe yesterday and tomorrow in connected sentences.

Grammar Priorities

1. The Perfekt — talking about the past

> **Ich habe gestern gearbeitet.**
> **Wir sind nach Berlin gefahren.**

Most verbs use *haben*. Verbs of movement or change — *gehen, fahren, kommen, aufstehen* — use *sein*.

2. Two-way prepositions — Wohin? or Wo?

> **Ich gehe in die Küche.** — *Wohin?* Movement → Akkusativ
> **Ich bin in der Küche.** — *Wo?* Location → Dativ

3. The dative

> **Ich gebe dir das Buch.**
> **Ich fahre mit dem Bus.**

The dative answers *Wem?* (to whom?) and always follows *aus, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu*.

4. Your first subordinate clauses

> **Ich lerne Deutsch, weil ich in Deutschland arbeite.**
> **Ich glaube, dass Deutsch interessant ist.**

Notice the verb: after *weil*, *dass* and *wenn* it goes to the **end**.

5. Polite requests

> **Ich hätte gern einen Kaffee.**
> **Könnten Sie mir bitte helfen?**
> **Ich würde gern am Freitag kommen.**

Small words, big effect: these forms make you sound friendly and polite.

🧠 Learn Phrases, Not Bare Words

Less useful	Better	Best
erinnern = remember	*sich an etwas erinnern*	**Ich kann mich nicht daran erinnern.**

Useful chunks:

- Angst vor etwas haben
- sich für etwas interessieren
- auf jemanden warten
- eine Entscheidung treffen
- Zeit verbringen
- einen Termin vereinbaren

🗣️ **Your A2 speaking anchor:** keep doing **one Natulang lesson every day** until you reach the end of A2. Add a **5-minute German-only period** whenever you can.

Talk Around Missing Words

If you don't know a word, explain around it. Forgot *Regenschirm* (umbrella)? Say:

> *Das Ding, das man benutzt, wenn es regnet.* — the thing you use when it rains.

That is real communication.

✍️ Weekly Writing

Write 80–120 words once a week. Possible topics:

- What I did last weekend
- My next holiday
- A difficult day
- My favourite place
- A problem I solved
- My plans for next year

Then **correct → rewrite → reuse.** Don't just mark the mistakes.

A2 Can-Do Checklist

- [ ] I can explain what I did yesterday.
- [ ] I can talk about my plans.
- [ ] I can make a simple appointment.
- [ ] I can explain a simple problem.
- [ ] I can ask follow-up questions.
- [ ] I can use *weil* and *dass*.
- [ ] I can use the Perfekt reliably.
- [ ] I can describe familiar places and people.
- [ ] I can manage a five-minute German-only conversation.
- [ ] I can write about 100 connected words.

Common A2 pitfall: ❌ switching to English whenever German gets difficult.

Fix: create a 5-Minute German-Only Rule. Once the timer starts, you continue in German — even if your sentences become very simple. Keep your daily Natulang lesson as your automatic speaking anchor.

Communication first. Elegance later.

9 B1 — Intermediate

B1 · GREEN ZONE

Your Goal

B1 is where you stop merely “building sentences” and start expressing real ideas. Your target: explain opinions, follow slower native material, and produce connected speech and writing.

Your Four Pillars

Pillar	Recommended	Backup	Minimum effective dose	Success check
📖 **Course**	Our lessons + Nicos Weg B1	B1 practice material from the Goethe-Institut Exam Trainings	20 min, 3× per week	I work through genuine B1 material instead of repeating A2.
🎧 **Input**	Easy German + DW Top-Thema	A German podcast for learners	15 min, 4× per week	I can explain the main message afterwards.
🧠 **Vocabulary**	Collocation and phrase cards	A personal vocabulary notebook	10 min daily	I use connectors and common word combinations automatically.
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Retelling + conversations	Video work with Language Reactor	2 retellings + 1 text per week	I can speak for 2–3 minutes about a familiar topic.

Natulang at B1

You have finished A2, so Natulang is now optional — keep it if you enjoy the extra repetition. Your main speaking training now becomes retelling, spontaneous answers, conversation, explaining and storytelling: your German must start working **without a script.**

The B1 Superpower: Retelling

Watch 2–5 minutes. Write down only five keywords. Close the video. Tell the story.

Example keywords: *Wohnung — Nachbar — Musik — Nacht — Polizei*

Then speak for 60–120 seconds. Your goal is not to reproduce the original. Your goal is to rebuild the meaning in your own German. (The full method is in The Method.)

Use Language Reactor Strategically

Language Reactor adds German and English subtitles, a pop-up dictionary and sentence-by-sentence replay to YouTube and Netflix (in Chrome or Edge on a computer).

Use it to understand a difficult line, replay it, notice a useful expression — and keep watching. Don't stop every ten seconds: the video must stay a message, not become a vocabulary mine.

languagereactor.com

🧠 B1 Vocabulary Focus

Connectors: *zuerst, danach, trotzdem, deshalb, außerdem, allerdings, einerseits … andererseits*

Collocations: *eine Entscheidung treffen · Erfahrungen sammeln · Verantwortung übernehmen · eine Rolle spielen · einen Vorschlag machen*

Useful frames:

Das hängt davon ab, ob …
Meiner Meinung nach …
Der Hauptgrund dafür ist …
Einerseits …, andererseits …

✍️ Weekly Writing

Write 150–200 words once a week with a clear structure: **introduction → main idea → explanation or example → second point → conclusion.** Ask for correction. Then rewrite at least the weakest paragraph.

B1 Can-Do Checklist

- ☐ I can explain why I agree or disagree.
- ☐ I can tell a connected story.
- ☐ I can retell the main points of a short video.
- ☐ I can follow slow native audio on familiar topics.
- ☐ I can describe experiences in detail.
- ☐ I can use several connectors without planning them.
- ☐ I can keep a five-minute conversation going.
- ☐ I can write 150–200 connected words.
- ☐ I can explain an unfamiliar word in German.

Common B1 pitfall: ❌ living permanently inside comfortable A2 material.

You understand almost everything, so you feel successful — but your German stops growing.

Fix: choose one genuine B1 course. Finish it. Then move forward.

Comfort maintains your level. Challenge changes it.

10 B2 — Upper Intermediate

B2 · GREEN ZONE

Your Goal

At B2, you learn to operate as an independent adult speaker: defend an opinion, understand normal native speech, organize complex information, adapt your wording and write structured texts.

Your Four Pillars

Pillar	Recommended	Backup	Minimum effective dose	Success check
📖 **Course**	Our lessons + one structured B2 course	Exam-oriented B2 material	20–30 min, 3× per week	I can use B2 grammar in spontaneous speech, not only in exercises.
🎧 **Input**	DW Video-Thema + Langsam gesprochene Nachrichten	Native podcasts on familiar topics	15–20 min, 4× per week	I understand the argument and the important details.
🧠 **Vocabulary**	Duden / DWDS + a bilingual dictionary + your correction deck	A personal collocation notebook	10 min daily	My new vocabulary comes more and more from real corrections and input.
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Weekly discussion + rewritten text	Our lessons / a tandem partner	1 discussion + 1 text per week	I can defend a position and react to counterarguments.

🧠 Change the Way You Use Dictionaries

At B2, start using a monolingual dictionary such as Duden or DWDS alongside your bilingual one. Instead of only asking "What does this word mean in English?", ask:

- Which words commonly appear with it? (DWDS's *Wortprofil* shows you.)
- Is it formal or informal?
- Which preposition follows it?
- What is a natural example?
- Would a native speaker actually use it here?

Build Vocabulary From Corrections

Your best vocabulary list is often not "50 new words from today's article." It is "10 expressions I tried to use — and used incorrectly."

> ❌ *eine Entscheidung machen*
> ✅ **eine Entscheidung treffen**

This correction closes a real gap in your German.

🗣️ Weekly Discussion

Choose one topic, for example:

- Should university education be free?
- Is remote work better?
- Should social media be restricted for children?
- What makes a good education system?
- Is artificial intelligence making us more productive?

Use frames such as:

> **Meiner Ansicht nach …**
> **Ein entscheidender Punkt ist …**
> **Man könnte dagegen einwenden, dass …**
> **Allerdings darf man nicht vergessen, dass …**
> **Zusammenfassend würde ich sagen …**

✍️ Weekly B2 Text

Write 250–400 words. Then: get feedback → identify recurring mistakes → rewrite the text → compare Version 1 and Version 2. Use the Big 5 Editing Checklist before you hand it in.

B2 Can-Do Checklist

- [ ] I can defend an opinion with several arguments.
- [ ] I can understand the main ideas of normal native podcasts.
- [ ] I can summarize a news item.
- [ ] I can distinguish informal and formal wording.
- [ ] I can discuss advantages and disadvantages spontaneously.
- [ ] I can write an organized text of 250+ words.
- [ ] I can identify some of my recurring errors myself.
- [ ] I can respond to a counterargument without preparing everything first.

Common B2 pitfall: ❌ fossilized errors. You speak quickly — but repeat the same incorrect structures.

Fix: slow down during deliberate practice. Use the Big 5. Build your vocabulary deck from corrections rather than random words.

At B2, accuracy starts catching up with fluency.

11 C1 — Advanced

C1 · PURPLE ZONE

Your Goal

C1 is not simply "B2 with more vocabulary." You learn to understand implicit meaning, follow humour, handle abstraction, speak spontaneously, shift register and express precise distinctions.

Your Four Pillars

Pillar	Recommended	Backup	Minimum effective dose	Success check
📖 **Course**	Structured C1 course + material from your field	Advanced exam material	20–30 min, 3× per week	I can handle complex structures outside textbook exercises.
🎧 **Input**	MAITHINK X, ARTE documentaries, native interviews	Advanced podcasts	20 min, 4× per week	I understand arguments, tone and implied meaning.
📖🧠 **Reading & vocabulary**	*Die Zeit*, *Der Spiegel* + professional material	High-quality essays and books	20 min, 3× per week	I notice differences in register and connotation.
🗣️✍️ **Output**	Complex debates + edited essays	Professional presentations	1 debate + 1 long text per week	I can explain abstract ideas without relying on memorized phrases.

Vocabulary: Stop Chasing More Words

At C1, your biggest gains often come from **precision**.

Neutral	More precise alternatives
wichtig	wesentlich, entscheidend, maßgeblich, zentral
deshalb	daher, folglich, demzufolge, aus diesem Grund

The question is no longer "Do I know another synonym?" It is: **which word fits this exact situation?**

Register Training

Take one idea — *the company made a bad decision* — and say it three ways:

> **Informal:** *Die Firma hat da echt eine schlechte Entscheidung getroffen.*
> **Neutral:** *Das Unternehmen hat eine problematische Entscheidung getroffen.*
> **Formal:** *Die Entscheidung des Unternehmens erwies sich als strategisch problematisch.*

This is C1 work.

🗣️ Debate Complex Topics

Technological unemployment · social cohesion · privacy · education policy · the ethics of artificial intelligence · demographic change · environmental responsibility.

Practise the full structure: position → justification → evidence or example → counterargument → response → conclusion.

✍️ C1 Writing

Write 300–500 words. Focus on logical structure, paragraph transitions, precision, register, sentence variety and self-editing. Then run the Big 5.

C1 Can-Do Checklist

- [ ] I can speak spontaneously about abstract topics.
- [ ] I understand implied attitudes in many conversations.
- [ ] I can follow sophisticated documentaries and interviews.
- [ ] I can use formal and informal registers appropriately.
- [ ] I can summarize and evaluate someone else's argument.
- [ ] I can reformulate an idea when my first wording fails.
- [ ] I can write clear texts of 300–500 words.
- [ ] I can identify recurring weaknesses in my own German.
- [ ] I can follow humour and some irony without everything being explained.

Common C1 pitfall: ❌ "I feel like I'm not improving anymore."

At C1, progress becomes less visible. Going from "I don't understand this" to "I understand this" is obvious. Going from "this sentence works" to "this sentence sounds more precise and natural" is much harder to notice.

Fix: track can-do statements, not feelings.

Advanced progress is often refinement, not expansion.

12 C2 — Mastery & Nuance

C2 · PURPLE ZONE

Your Goal

C2 means functioning with extremely high flexibility and precision. You aim to understand virtually everything, notice subtle implications, speak spontaneously, choose your wording deliberately and play with style and register.

Core Habits

📖 **Read demanding native material.** Rotate between literature, essays, philosophy, long-form journalism and material from your professional field.

🎧 **Listen without learner support.** Lectures, debates, interviews, documentaries, comedy and unedited conversations.

🗣️ **Debate abstraction.** Ethics, philosophy, social systems, political theory, psychology, science and professional questions.

✍️ **Edit for style.** Don't only ask "Is this grammatically correct?" Ask: **"Is this the strongest formulation?"**

🧠 **Vocabulary focus:** connotation, collocation, idiom, nuance, register and rhetorical effect.

C2 Weekly Routine

- [ ] 3 × 20 minutes of demanding reading
- [ ] 1 × 30 minutes of advanced discussion
- [ ] 1 × a 300–500-word text with feedback
- [ ] 1 × a native podcast or lecture
- [ ] Review your high-level stylistic corrections

C2 Self-Check

Can you ...

- [ ] catch implicit meaning?
- [ ] understand humour and irony?
- [ ] adapt your register instantly?
- [ ] distinguish several near-synonyms?
- [ ] speak for five minutes on an abstract topic without preparation?
- [ ] reformulate an idea elegantly?
- [ ] notice when a sentence is correct but stylistically weak?

"C2 is not the end — it's the beginning of playing with language."

PART 3

Skills Toolbox

Use these chapters whenever you need them: pronunciation, mediation, self-correction, the science behind the method, realistic timelines and exams, bringing German into your life, common traps — and how to stay motivated.

13 Pronunciation & Prosody

Good pronunciation does not mean erasing your accent or sounding exactly like one particular native speaker. The goal is:

clear + effortless + easy to understand

The Essential Rules

Vowels

#	Rule	Examples
1	**Vowel length changes meaning.** Before a double consonant a vowel is usually short; a doubled vowel or a vowel + **h** is long.	*Stadt* (short) — *Staat* (long) · *Mitte* — *Miete*
2	**ie** is a long "ee".	Liebe, sieben, spielen
3	**ei** sounds like English "eye". *Trick: say the English name of the second letter — i**e** → "ee", e**i** → "eye".*	mein, klein, drei
4	**eu** and **äu** sound like "oy".	heute, Leute, Häuser
5	**ä** sounds like the *e* in *bed*.	Mädchen, spät, Äpfel
6	**ö**: say "ay" (as in *say*) and round your lips.	schön, hören, Köln
7	**ü**: say "ee" (as in *see*) and round your lips.	Tür, müde, über
8	A final **-e** is always pronounced — a short, relaxed "uh".	Name, bitte, Sonne
9	A final **-er** sounds like a short, dark "a".	Lehrer, Vater, aber

Consonants

#	Rule	Examples
10	**s** before a vowel buzzes like English “z”; **ß** and **ss** are a sharp “s”.	Sonne, sieben, lesen · Straße, essen
11	**sch** = “sh”.	Schule, Tisch
12	**sp** and **st** at the start of a word or word part = “shp”, “sht”.	Sport, sprechen, Straße, verstehen
13	**z** and **tz** = “ts”.	Zeit, zehn, Katze
14	**w** = English “v”.	Wasser, wohnen
15	**v** = “f” in most German words — but “v” in many loanwords.	Vater, Vogel, viel · Video, Klavier
16	**j** = English “y”.	ja, jung, Jahr
17	**ch** after **i, e, ä, ö, ü, ei, eu** or a consonant: the soft *ich*-sound.	ich, Bücher, schlecht, Milch
18	**ch** after **a, o, u, au**: the rough *ach*-sound.	Bach, Buch, auch
19	A final **-ig** sounds like “-ich” in standard German.	wichtig, König, zwanzig
20	A final **b, d, g** sounds like **p, t, k**.	lieb, Rad, Tag, und
21	**qu** = “kv”. **pf**: pronounce both letters.	Quatsch, bequem · Apfel, Pferd
22	The German **r** comes from the back of the throat (or is rolled in some regions) — never use an English “r”.	rot, Reise, warum
23	**h** is pronounced at the start of a word, but silent after a vowel — where it makes the vowel long.	Haus, heute · sehr, fahren, Uhr

Stress and melody

#	Rule	Examples
24	Stress is usually on the **first syllable of the word stem**.	ARbeiten, SPREchen, LEHrer
25	Separable prefixes are stressed; **be-, ge-, er-, ver-, zer-, ent-** never are.	AUFstehen, EINkaufen · verSTEhen, beZAHlen, entSCHEIden
26	**-tion** sounds like “tsion” and carries the stress.	InformaTION, StaTION

Two Fossilized Errors to Prevent Early

1. Vowel length. Compare *bieten* and *bitten*, *Staat* and *Stadt*. One vowel is longer — and the difference changes the meaning. Listen before you guess pronunciation from spelling.

2. Word stress. Don’t pronounce German word by word with equal force. German has rhythm. Learn *eine EntSCHEIdung TREFfen* as one spoken unit.

The Shadowing Technique

Shadowing means listening to a native (or high-quality) German recording and imitating it very closely: sounds, rhythm, stress, pauses and melody.

1. 🎧 **Listen.** Listen to one sentence several times. Don't speak yet.
2. 🗣️ **Imitate.** Repeat together with the speaker. Copy the music of the sentence, not only the words.
3. 🎙️ **Record & compare.** Record yourself and compare stress, timing, vowel length, consonants and intonation.

Suggested Pronunciation Tools

Use tools to support focused practice — and don't use four tools for the same job.

🎙️ ShadowGerman

Level A1–C2 (A1 free)
Cost All of A1 free · premium for A2–C2
Works on iPhone · iPad · Mac

Shadowing practice — listen to a native sentence, repeat, record and compare.

iPhone
App Store

🎙️ LingFast

Level A1+
Cost Free to start · in-app purchases
Works on iPhone · Android

Extra speaking and pronunciation practice with AI feedback.

iPhone
App Store

Android
Google Play

🔎 Faztaa

Level A1–C2
Cost Free
Works on Web · iPhone · Android

German–English dictionary and translator with audio — look up words by typing, voice or camera.

faztaa.com

🤖 SprechenAI

Level A1–C2
Cost Free to start · subscription options
Works on iPhone · Android

Extra AI conversation practice when no human partner is available.

iPhone
App Store

Android
Google Play

14 Mediation — The Fifth Skill

Language is not only listening, speaking, reading and writing. There is another important skill:

Mediation

Mediation means helping information move from one person, language or context to another. You may summarize, explain, simplify, translate the meaning, clarify cultural context or bridge a misunderstanding. You don't always need a literal translation — you need to preserve the message.

Examples by Level

A2 — Read a short German text, then explain the main idea in your own simple words.

> **Der Zug fällt heute aus. Reisende können den Bus nehmen.**

Your explanation:

> *Der Zug fährt heute nicht. Man kann den Bus nehmen.*

B1 / B2 — Read a German news headline. Explain it to someone who doesn't speak German: what happened, who is involved and why it matters.

C1 / C2 — Two people disagree because of different cultural expectations. Explain what each person means, why the misunderstanding happened and what nuance is missing.

Practice Exercise

1. 📖 Read one short German article.
2. Close it.
3. Identify the three most important points.
4. Explain them to a friend in your strongest language.
5. No friend available? Record yourself.

If you can explain information clearly, you probably understood it deeply.

15 Self-Correction & Editing

Advanced learners improve faster when they learn to become their own first editor.

The Big 5 — From B2 to C2

1. Verb form & position. Is the verb conjugated correctly? Is the finite verb in position 2? Does a verb belong at the end? Did I separate a separable verb correctly?

2. Case. Check nominative, accusative, dative and genitive — especially after prepositions, verbs and in adjective–noun combinations.

3. Connector logic. Don't choose connectors because they "sound advanced." Ask: *what relationship am I expressing?*

Function	Examples
Cause	weil, da
Result	deshalb, daher, folglich
Contrast	obwohl, allerdings, dennoch
Addition	außerdem, darüber hinaus

4. Adjective endings. Check article + adjective + noun:

> **ein interessantes Buch**
> **mit einem interessanten Buch**

5. Register. Who am I speaking to? Is this formal, neutral, casual, academic or professional?

Rewrite, Don't Just Fix

> ❌ *Viele Leute benutzen Auto weil es ist einfacher.*
> ✅ **Viele Menschen benutzen das Auto, weil es einfacher ist.**
> ✅ **Viele Menschen entscheiden sich für das Auto, weil es im Alltag häufig praktischer ist.**

Correction repairs the sentence. Rewriting develops your German.

Mistake Log

Error	Correction	Rule / pattern	Review date

Review rhythm: review important errors after 1 day → 3 days → 1 week → 2–4 weeks. A full-page version is in Printable Templates.

16 Why This Works — The Science

You don't need to become a neuroscientist to learn German efficiently. But four principles matter.

1. Spaced Repetition

Don't review everything equally. Review information just before you are likely to forget it — for example on Day 1 → Day 2 → Day 4 → Day 8 → Day 16. Apps such as Anki automate this for you.

2. Interleaving

Don't always study one grammar topic for an hour. Mix related skills: 5 minutes of vocabulary, 5 of listening, 5 of speaking, 5 of grammar. This forces your brain to decide which knowledge it needs — which is much closer to real communication.

3. Retrieval Practice

Re-reading feels easy. Remembering without looking is harder — and far more useful. Instead of re-reading *sich interessieren für*, cover the answer and ask: "Which preposition follows *sich interessieren*?" Then retrieve it: **für + Akkusativ.**

4. Desirable Difficulty

Don't ask for the answer instantly. Struggle productively for a few seconds: try to remember, try to build the sentence — then check. That moment of effort is what makes it stick.

Tool Audit

Once a month, ask yourself:

- [ ] Does this tool train a skill I actually need?
- [ ] Am I using it consistently?
- [ ] Can I explain what it contributes?
- [ ] Do I already have another tool doing the same job?
- [ ] Am I learning German — or organizing apps?

If two tools do the same job, keep the better one.

> **Important exception:** from **A0 through the end of A2**, Natulang is a **core speaking habit** — not an app to audit away just because another resource looks newer or more exciting. **Rule: one Natulang lesson per day.**

17 Realistic Timelines & Exams

Learning speed varies enormously — with the languages you already speak, your intensity, your teaching, your contact with German and your goals. The ranges below are for planning, not promises.

How Long Does Each Level Take?

The Goethe-Institut estimates the following **total hours of learning from zero**. The two columns on the right turn those hours into months.

To reach	Total hours from zero	Steady pace — about 4–5 hours/week (30 min a day + a weekly lesson)	Intensive pace — about 12 hours/week
A1	60–150	3–8 months	1–3 months
A2	150–260	8–13 months	3–5 months
B1	260–490	1–2 years	5–9 months
B2	450–600	2–2½ years	9–12 months
C1	600–750	2½–3 years	1–1¼ years
C2	750+	3 years +	1¼ years +

Hours: Goethe-Institut, "Wie lange dauert es, Deutsch zu lernen?" (60-minute hours; 80–200 lessons of 45 minutes for A1, and so on). Months are calculated from those hours.

What counts as an hour? Focused, active learning: lessons, course work, speaking, writing and attentive listening or reading. German playing in the background helps, but it counts much less. And the higher you go, the more you need real-life German on top of your study time.

Exam Pathways

Exam	Levels	Typical purpose
Goethe-Zertifikat	A1–C2	Internationally recognized general German certificates
telc Deutsch	A1–C2	General, job-related and university versions (e.g. *telc Deutsch C1 Hochschule*)
ÖSD	A1–C2	The Austrian German diploma, recognized internationally
DTZ — Deutsch-Test für Zuwanderer	A2–B1 (scaled)	The final exam of the German integration course
TestDaF	B2–C1	University admission in Germany
DSH	about B2–C2 (DSH-1 to DSH-3)	University admission, taken at the university itself

Which certificate do you need? That depends on your situation, and the rules change. For example, an A1 certificate is often required for a family-reunion visa, and B1 is the usual requirement for permanent residence and naturalization in Germany. Always check the current official requirements for your case.

Exam Training Is Not the Same as Skipping a Level

You can sometimes prepare quickly for a particular exam format. That doesn't mean the underlying language level has magically appeared. Short preparation periods usually focus on task types, timing, exam vocabulary, speaking formats, writing structure and scoring criteria. Free official model tests: Goethe-Institut Exam Trainings.

Exam technique can raise your score. It cannot replace the language itself.

18 Bring German Into Your Life

You don't need to live in Germany to create a German environment. Change small parts of the life you already have.

Five Easy Immersion Habits

📱 **1. Change your phone language.** Switch some devices or apps to German. You will see words like *Einstellungen, Nachrichten, Speichern, Löschen, Weiter, Zurück* again and again.

📺 **2. Watch one German episode per week.** A series, reality TV, a documentary, an interview or an entertainment show. At lower levels, subtitles are fine. Your aim is not 100% comprehension — it is growing familiarity.

🤝 **3. Join real German-speaking environments.** Try a *Verein* (club), a *Sprachcafé*, a *Stammtisch*, a community event, a hobby group or a sports club. German becomes easier when it is attached to a real purpose.

🎧 **4. Do one daily task in German.** Read a recipe, read one news headline (try nachrichtenleicht from A2), listen to a five-minute podcast, check the weather in German, search for information in German.

🗣️ **5. Use a language tandem.** Use a clear split — 50% German, 50% your partner's target language — and don't let the stronger language take over the whole conversation.

19 Common Pitfalls & Fossilized Errors

Trap	One-line fix
Pronouncing **ü** like **u**.	Isolate the sound and practise the mouth position deliberately: say "ee", then round your lips.
Ignoring vowel length.	Copy whole words from audio instead of trusting the spelling.
Learning nouns without articles.	Learn **der / die / das + plural** with every noun, from Day 1.
Avoiding speaking.	Speak every day, even for five minutes.
Looking up every unknown word.	Ask whether the word blocks understanding. If not, keep going.
App-hopping.	Keep one main tool per learning job.
Collecting vocabulary without reviewing it.	Retrieval beats collection.
Ignoring corrections.	Put recurring corrections into your mistake log.
Only consuming easy material.	Keep roughly 10–20% of your study challenging.

Special A0–A2 Warning

The most damaging beginner trap is:

"I'm not ready to speak yet."

You become ready to speak **by speaking.**

> **Fix:** complete **one Natulang lesson every day** from A0 through the end of A2. Five minutes of imperfect speaking beat zero minutes of perfect intentions.

20 Motivation & Mindset

Motivation changes. Your system has to survive the days when motivation disappears.

The Intermediate Plateau

At beginner level, progress is dramatic. At B1–C1, the changes get smaller: you move from "I can explain this" to "I can explain this clearly, naturally and with better vocabulary." That improvement is real — but harder to feel. **Track evidence, not emotion.**

The Good-Mistake Mindset

A useful mistake tells you: *here is the edge of my current ability.* That is valuable information. If you never make mistakes, your practice is probably too easy.

The Bad-Day Rule

Never judge your whole German on one bad conversation. You may be tired, stressed or distracted, talking about an unfamiliar subject, or talking to a difficult speaker. Language ability fluctuates. Long-term performance is what counts.

Never Miss Twice

Missing one day is normal. Missing two in a row starts a new habit — so after a missed day, do at least your minimum the next day.

Celebrate Small Wins

- [ ] My first full German conversation
- [ ] My first phone call in German
- [ ] My first joke understood
- [ ] My first podcast understood without subtitles
- [ ] My first page read without a dictionary
- [ ] My first compliment on my German
- [ ] My first spontaneous dream in German
- [ ] My first time explaining something complicated

When You Feel Stuck

Problem	Redirect
Am I getting enough input?	Increase listening and reading.
Do I understand, but freeze when speaking?	Increase retelling and spontaneous output.
Do I speak fluently but inaccurately?	Increase correction and deliberate editing.
Do I forget vocabulary?	Increase retrieval and spaced repetition.
Am I overwhelmed?	Reduce the number of resources.
Am I bored?	Increase the difficulty or change the topic — not the whole system.

PART 4

Tools & Templates

Every resource in this guide with a QR code — scan it with your phone camera, or click the name in the PDF — plus printable planners, trackers and worksheets for your weekly routine.

21 Resource Directory

Choose resources by the job they do. **Do not try to use everything listed here.** Pick one per job, use it consistently, and swap it only when it stops working for you.

Quick Resource Map

Job	Core	Backup
🗣️ Speaking A0–A2	Natulang	Our lessons / voice recordings
🗣️ Speaking B1+	Real conversation + retelling	Natulang review / AI speaking (SprechenAI)
📖 Course	Our lessons + Nicos Weg	Textbook / Goethe practice material
🎧 Listening	DW / Easy German	A podcast for learners
📰 Reading	nachrichtenleicht → authentic texts	Graded readers
✍️ Writing	One corrected text per week	A journal
🧠 Vocabulary	Anki	Paper cards
🎬 Video	Easy German / native content	Language Reactor support
🎙️ Pronunciation	Shadowing	ShadowGerman / LingFast

🗣️ Speaking

🗣️ Natulang

Level A0–A2 core · optional afterwards
Cost First lessons free · subscription for the full course
Works on iPhone · Android

Your daily speaking habit — one lesson per day (about 10–15 min). You speak every answer out loud; speech recognition checks it.

natulang.com

🤖 SprechenAI

Level A1–C2
Cost Free to start · subscription options
Works on iPhone · Android

Extra AI conversation practice when no human partner is available.

iPhone
App Store

Android
Google Play

📖 Courses & Grammar

📖 Nicos Weg (DW)

Level A1 → A2 → B1
Cost Free
Works on Web · iPhone · Android

A complete free video course with exercises and grammar pages. Your structured path from zero to B1.

learngerman.dw.com › Nicos Weg

🎓 Goethe-Institut Exam Trainings

Level A1–C2
Cost Free
Works on Web

Official model tests and practice sets for every level — reading, listening, writing and speaking.

goethe.de › Exam trainings

🧰 German Learning Toolkit

Level A1 (more levels coming)
Cost Free
Works on Web

Free one-page grammar summaries with practice exercises — articles, present tense, word order, accusative and dative.

github.com/ DeutschFokus

🎧 Listening & Watching

🎧 DW Learn German

Level A1–C1
Cost Free
Works on Web · iPhone · Android

Free courses, videos, audio and news for every level — from Deutsche Welle, Germany's international broadcaster.

learngerman.dw.com

🎬 Easy German

Level "Super Easy German" A1–B1 · street interviews B1–C2
Cost Free · optional membership
Works on YouTube · podcast

Real Germans speaking real German, with German and English subtitles.

youtube.com/ @EasyGerman

📺 DW Video-Thema

Level B2
Cost Free
Works on Web · YouTube

Short video reports on society, culture and politics, with subtitles and exercises.

learngerman.dw.com › Video-Thema

🎬 Language Reactor

Level B1+
Cost Free · optional Pro
Works on Chrome / Edge on a computer

Dual subtitles, a pop-up dictionary and sentence-by-sentence replay for YouTube and Netflix.

languagereactor.com

📰 News & Reading

🗞️ nachrichtenleicht

Level A2–B1
Cost Free
Works on Web · podcast

The week's news in "Einfache Sprache" (plain German) from Deutschlandfunk — your first real news in German.

nachrichtenleicht.de

📰 DW Top-Thema

Level B1
Cost Free
Works on Web · podcast

Short news reports in simplified German, with audio, text and vocabulary.

learngerman.dw.com › Top-Thema

📻 Langsam gesprochene Nachrichten

Level B2
Cost Free
Works on Web · podcast

Real daily news (Monday–Saturday), read slowly and clearly, with the full text.

learngerman.dw.com › Langsam gesprochene Nachrichten

Native reading (B2/C1+): newspapers, magazines, professional journals, essays and literature — for example *Die Zeit*, *Der Spiegel*, *Süddeutsche Zeitung*, tagesschau.de and publications from your field. Backup at every level: graded readers at your CEFR level.

🧠 Vocabulary & Dictionaries

🧠 Anki

Level All levels
Cost Free on computer, web and Android · paid on iPhone
Works on Windows · Mac · Linux · Android · iPhone · web

Spaced-repetition flashcards — it shows each card just before you would forget it.

apps.ankiweb.net

🔎 Faztaa

Level A1–C2
Cost Free
Works on Web · iPhone · Android

German–English dictionary and translator with audio — look up words by typing, voice or camera.

faztaa.com

📚 Duden

Level B2+
Cost Free online
Works on Web

The standard monolingual German dictionary — spelling, meaning, grammar and style.

duden.de

📚 DWDS

Level B2+
Cost Free
Works on Web

Monolingual dictionary with real example sentences and a "Wortprofil" showing which words go together.

dwds.de

A good flashcard contains: the phrase, the article and plural (for nouns), the preposition (for verbs like *warten auf*), and one useful example sentence — ideally one about your own life.

🎙️ Pronunciation

🎙️ ShadowGerman

Level A1–C2 (A1 free)
Cost All of A1 free · premium for A2–C2
Works on iPhone · iPad · Mac

Shadowing practice — listen to a native sentence, repeat, record and compare.

iPhone
App Store

🎙️ LingFast

Level A1+
Cost Free to start · in-app purchases
Works on iPhone · Android

Extra speaking and pronunciation practice with AI feedback.

iPhone
App Store

Android
Google Play

22 Printable Templates

Print the pages you need — or fill them in digitally. Each template supports one habit from this guide.

Template	Use it for	How often
1 · SMARTA Goal Sheet	Setting one clear, realistic goal	Every 6–12 weeks
2 · Weekly Study Planner	Planning your week	Every Sunday
3 · Weekly Progress Dashboard	Tracking habits, confidence and wins	Every week
4 · Vocabulary Card	Making flashcards that actually work	Whenever you add phrases
5 · Retelling Worksheet	The 5-Keyword Method	Twice a week from B1
6 · Self-Assessment	Checking your level with can-do statements	Every 1–2 months
7 · Mistake Log	Turning recurring errors into correct German	After every lesson
8 · Natulang Habit Tracker	Your daily speaking habit (A0–A2)	Every day
9 · Lesson Notes	Getting the most out of our lessons	Every lesson

Printing tip: you don’t need to print this whole guide. Print Templates 3, 7 and 9 a few times — those are the ones you will use every week.

Template 1 — SMARTA Goal Sheet

Current level: _____ Target level / ability: _____

S — Specific

Exactly what do I want to achieve?

M — Measurable

How will I know I have achieved it?

A — Achievable

Why is this realistic?

R — Relevant

Why does this matter to me?

T — Time-bound

My deadline: _____

A — Action-oriented

Every week I will:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Template 2 — Weekly Study Planner

Week of: _____

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
📖 Course							
🎧 Listening							
📖 Reading							
🧠 Vocabulary							
🗣️ Speaking							
✍️ Writing							
⏱️ Minutes							

My main goal this week

One thing I want to improve

What worked well last week?

Template 3 — Weekly Progress Dashboard

Week of: _____

Habit grid

Habit	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
📖 Course	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🎧 Input	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🧠 Vocabulary	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🗣️ Speaking (A0–A2: Natulang)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
✍️ Writing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Vocabulary milestones — words and phrases I can actively use

- ☐ 100
- ☐ 250
- ☐ 500
- ☐ 1,000
- ☐ 2,000
- ☐ 3,000+

☐ I have stopped obsessing over the number and started focusing on usage.

This week I can now ...

☐ _____

☐ _____

☐ _____

Confidence rating — 1 = very difficult, 5 = confident

Skill	1	2	3	4	5
🎧 Listening	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
🗣️ Speaking	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
📖 Reading	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
✍️ Writing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

⭐ One win of the week

Template 4 — Vocabulary Card

Copy this layout onto index cards or into Anki. One phrase per card.

Front	Back
German word or phrase Article: der / die / das / — Plural	Meaning Collocation / preposition Example sentence My own example

Template 5 — Retelling Worksheet

Source title / topic: _____

My five keywords

1	2	3	4	5

Now close the source.

🗣️ Explain what you understood for: ☐ 30 sec ☐ 60 sec ☐ 2 min ☐ 3+ min

What could I not express?

A useful expression I learned

Template 6 — Self-Assessment

Current level: _____ Date: _____

🎧 Listening — I can …

- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

🗣️ Speaking — I can …

- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

📖 Reading — I can …

- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

✍️ Writing — I can …

- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

My next target: _____

Template 7 — Mistake Log

Review each error after 1 day → 3 days → 1 week → 2–4 weeks.

Error	Correction	Rule / pattern	Review date

This week's most important recurring mistake

My new example sentence

Template 8 — Natulang Habit Tracker

A0 → end of A2 · Rule: one lesson per day. Month: _____

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Week 1 — Natulang lesson	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 1 — spoke aloud	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 2 — Natulang lesson	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 2 — spoke aloud	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 3 — Natulang lesson	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 3 — spoke aloud	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 4 — Natulang lesson	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 4 — spoke aloud	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Lessons completed this month: _____ / 28
Current Natulang level / unit: _____

One sentence I can say more easily now

Template 9 — Lesson Notes

Date: _____ Lesson no.: _____ Topic: _____

Before the lesson — my questions

Something I want to tell in German

New phrases — as complete sentences

Corrections

❌ What I said	✅ The correct version

Homework

One phrase I will use this week: _____

See You in Lesson One

Bring your questions — and don't worry about getting it right yet.

You do not need to understand everything.
You do not need to speak perfectly.
You do not need the perfect app.
You do not need three free hours every day.

You need to come back tomorrow.

One sentence becomes ten. Ten become a conversation. A conversation becomes confidence. Eventually, German stops feeling like something you study. It becomes something you **use**.

Los geht's!

LET'S GO